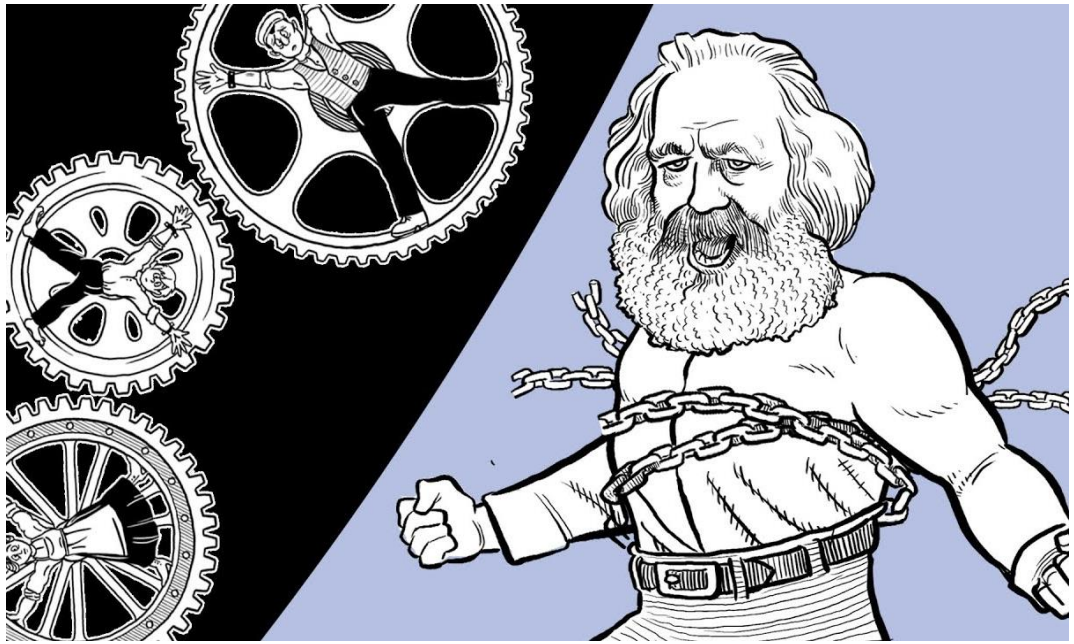
4 Foucauldian Perspectives

GEB2508 AI and Society

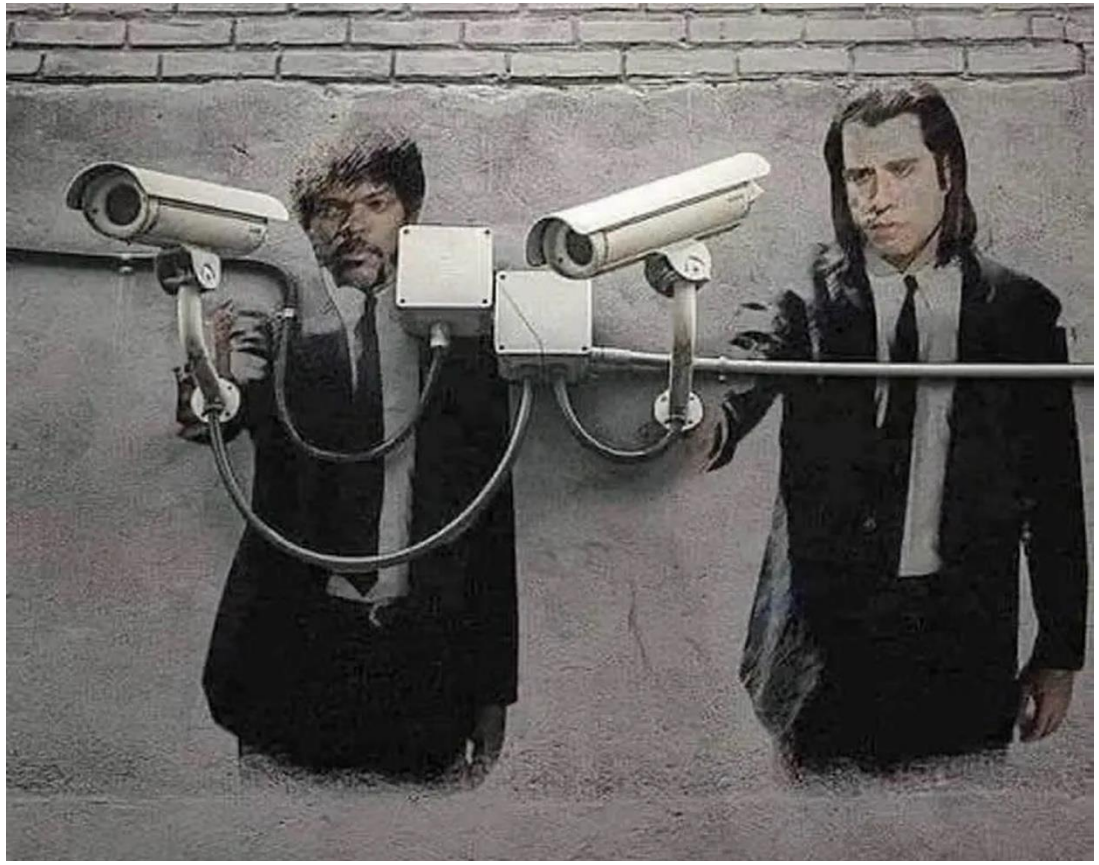
Review of Last Class

- Marxist Theory
  - Surplus Labor and Value
  - Exploitation and Inequality
  - Base and Superstructure
- Marxian Perspectives on Technology
  - Machinery and Luddism
  - Division of Labor and Alienation
  - Technological Unemployment



Content

- Foucauldian Perspectives on (Scientific) Knowledge
  - Power and Knowledge
  - Truth and Discourse
  - Biopower and Governmentality
- Foucauldian Perspectives on Technology
  - The Panopticon
  - Surveillance Technology



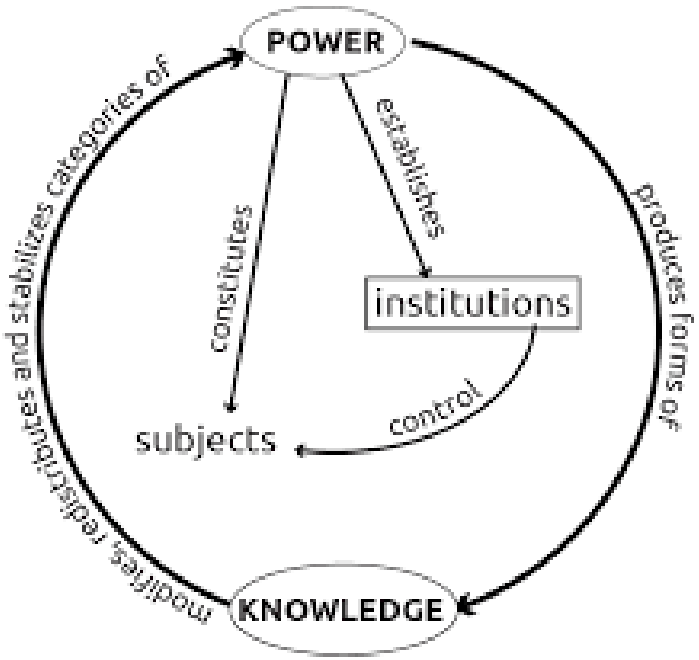
Michel Foucault (1926-1984)

- French historian and philosopher; trained in the history of medical and psychological sciences
- Educated at the Lycée Henri-IV and the École Normale Supérieure
- Lifelong political activist: in the French intellectual tradition of combining critical analysis with active engagement in social and political issues

Deleuze, Sartre and Foucault

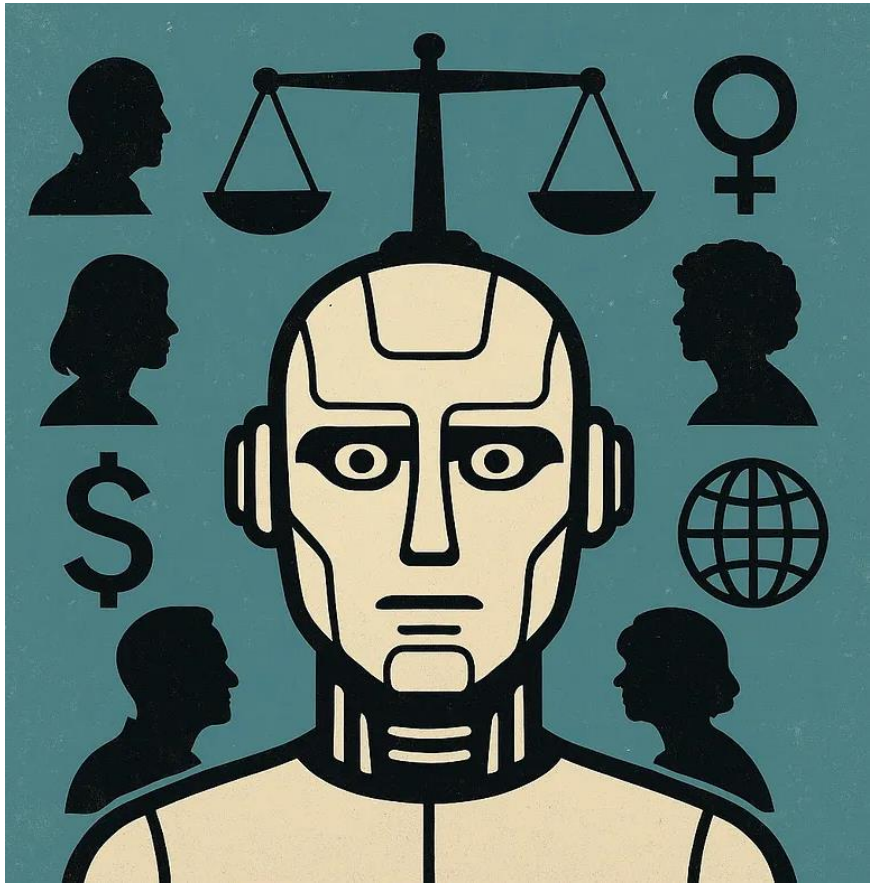
Power-Knowledge Nexus

- "Truth" is produced by institutions and by the discourse formulated by institutions
  - Each society has its own "**truth discourse**" (e.g., religion, science, nationalism)
- Development of **professional** groups who:
  - Claim to understand humans (knowledge)
  - Prescribe to them how to act (power)
- The norm becomes **common sense** when internalized and institutionalized.



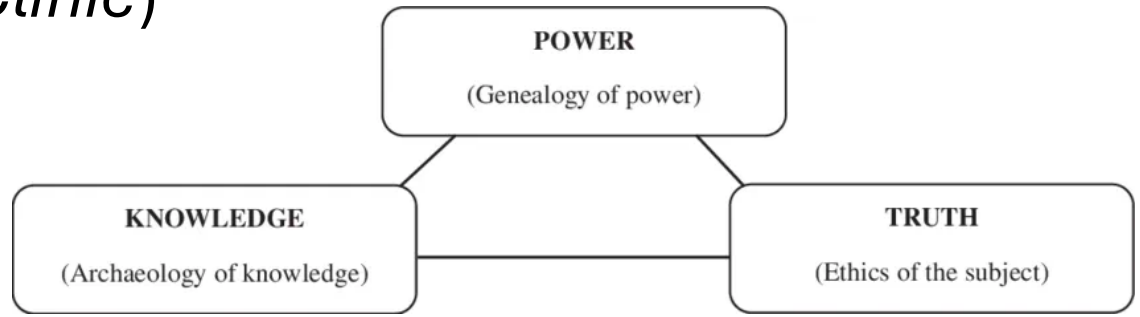
AI as A Technology of Power-Knowledge

- AI systems as **knowledge-producing** machines.
  - Classification, prediction, ranking.
- How algorithmic outputs gain authority as “objective,” “neutral,” or “scientific.”
  - AI as part of the **regime of truth**
- The shift from **explanation** to **prediction**
  - Strengthening governmental power



Methodology: History of the Present

- Archaeology of knowledge
  - The use of specific **language** imposes substantial constraints on how people can think and consequently act. (e.g., *Madness and Civilization, The Birth of the Clinic*)

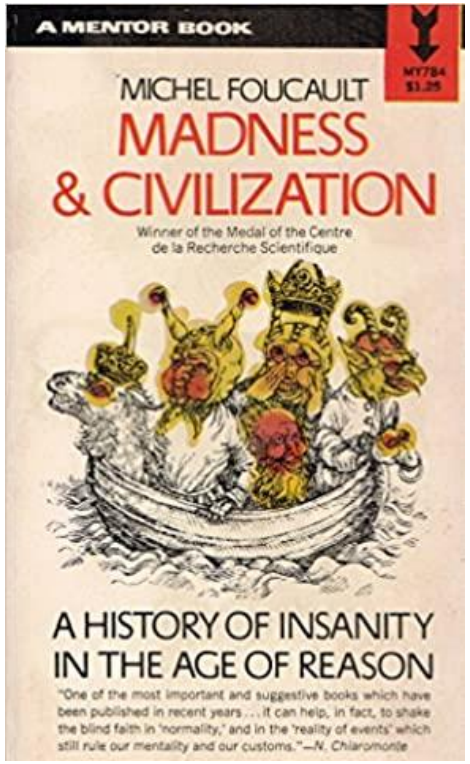


- Genealogy of knowledge
  - History is the origins of present rules. What makes certain ideas, practices, and institutions in the present appear "**normal**"? (e.g., Discipline and Punish, *The* History of Sexuality)

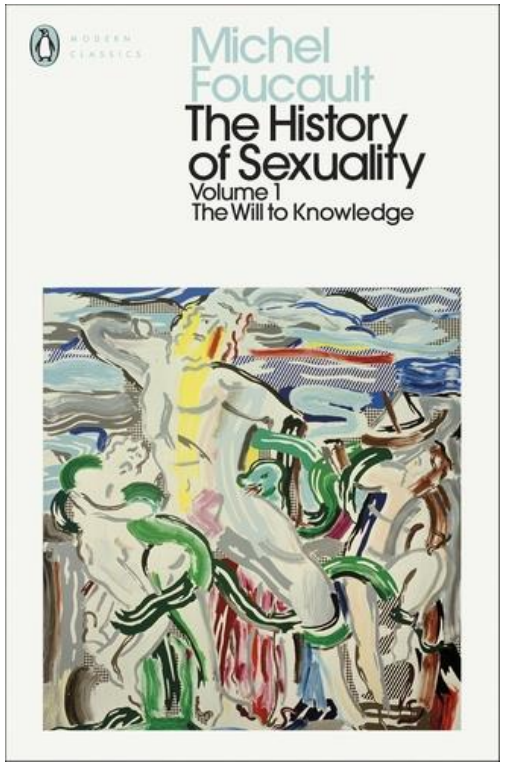
Discourse

- Discourse: a **system** of language that shapes and regulates the way we think, speak, and behave.
  - Definition and prohibition: set the **limits** of what can be said or thought
  - Division and rejection: classify people and create **distinctions**
  - Opposition between false and true: establish what counts as “truth”

Foucauldian Discourse Analysis



Madness: framed as a threat to industrial order and productivity, **medicalized** and managed, and used to construct a **rational subject** aligned with capitalist norms.



Sexuality: Western scientific discourse has produced sexuality as an object of knowledge, while **heteronormativity** positions heterosexuality as the natural basis of relationships and family structures.

Power

- Definition: the capacity to influence or control others' behavior, even **against** their will
  - Power (权力) vs. Rights (权利)
- Major sources of power
  - Violence: use/threat of **physical** force
  - Monopoly: exclusive control over tangible or intangible resources
  - Ideology: **align** individual desires with the interests of those in power

Foucauldian Concept of Power

Sovereign Power

- The authority of a sovereign ruler, defined by the right to kill or to let live (control over life and death)
- **Repressive** in nature, often exercised through deprivation
- Operates primarily over a **territory**

Bio-Power (Capillary Power)

- A pervasive form of power that regulates the behavior of individuals
- Its primary objective is to **produce** docile, compliant, and submissive individuals.
- Discipline functions at the level of **individuals**

Discipline

- External discipline: regulation imposed by authorities (e.g., parents, teachers)
- Self-discipline: **internalization** of disciplinary rules
- Discipline aims to produce normalized and compliant *subjects* who **fit** established power relations and thereby **reproduce** the system.

Biopower

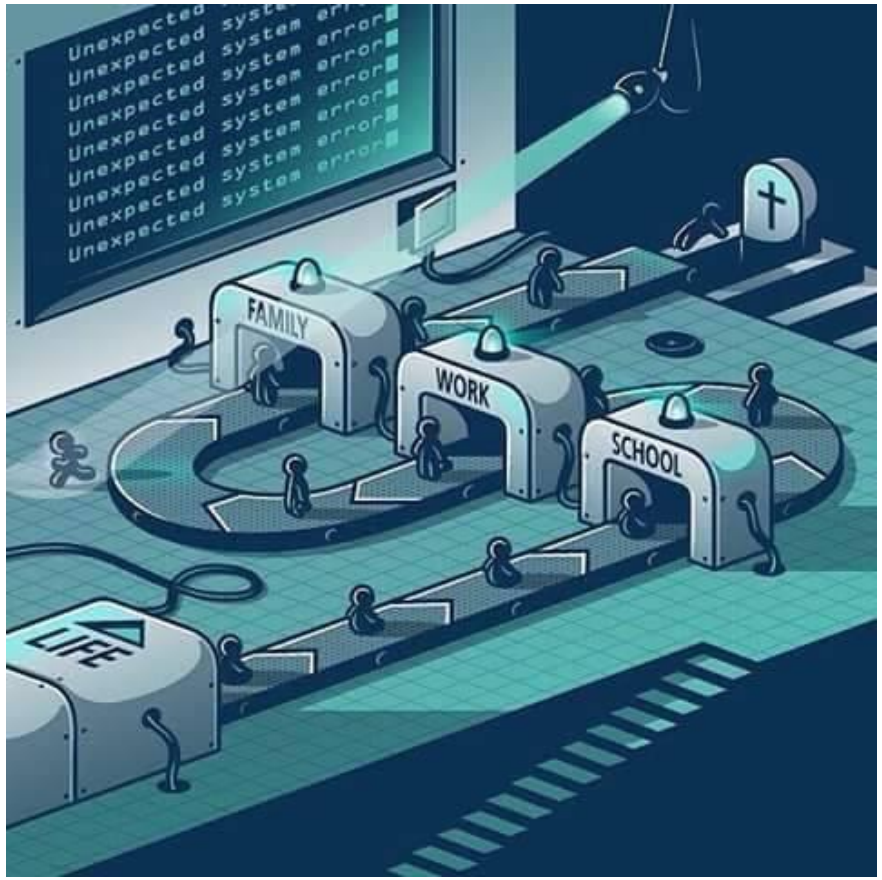
- The rise of biopower is closely linked to the rise of **capitalism**: population as a **workforce**
  - Birth and death rates, marriage rates, fertility rates, age distribution, etc.
  - Sex and sexuality: directly related to **reproduction** and population growth
- Biopower is the political technology used to manage, control, and **normalize** populations.
  - Emergence of scientific fields like demographics and public health

AI and Biopolitics

- AI as biopolitical infrastructure: tools for managing life and populations
- From **individuals** to **populations**: govern through statistics, risk profiles, and aggregate patterns
- Differential **valuation** of lives: unequal regimes of protection, care, and surveillance
- **Normalization** through data: define and flag “abnormal,” “outlier,” and “high-risk” subjects

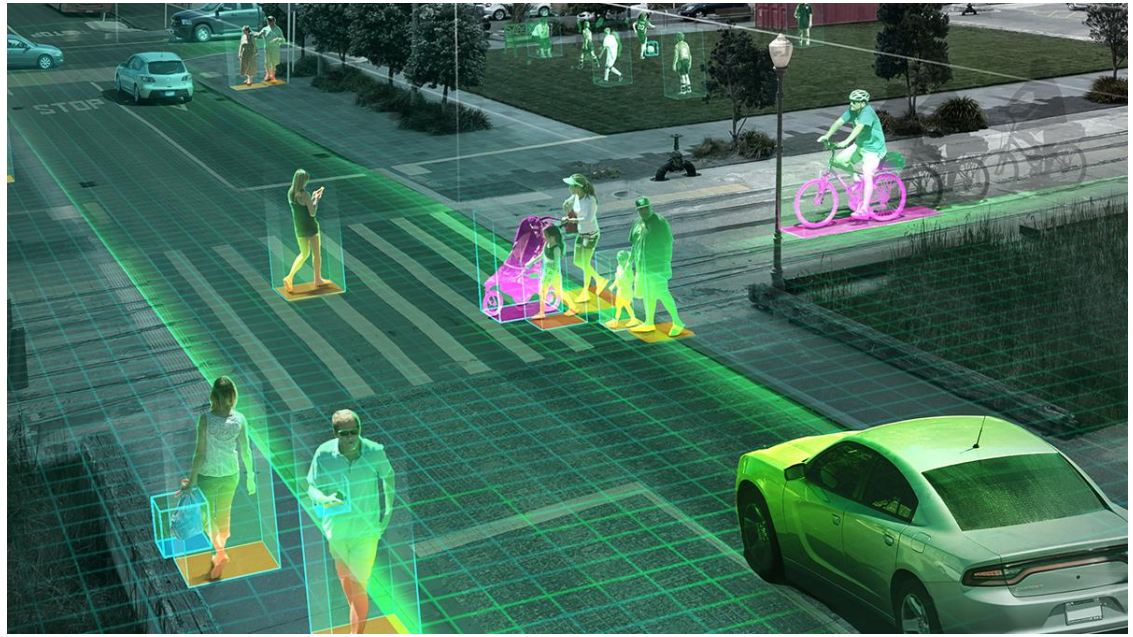
Governmentality

- Key focus: techniques, rationalities, and institutions of governance
- Managerial regulation of populations: governing through statistics, norms, and averages
- Governmentality through **freedom**: power steers “free” choices
- Knowledge-power link: expertise (statistics, data) enables governance



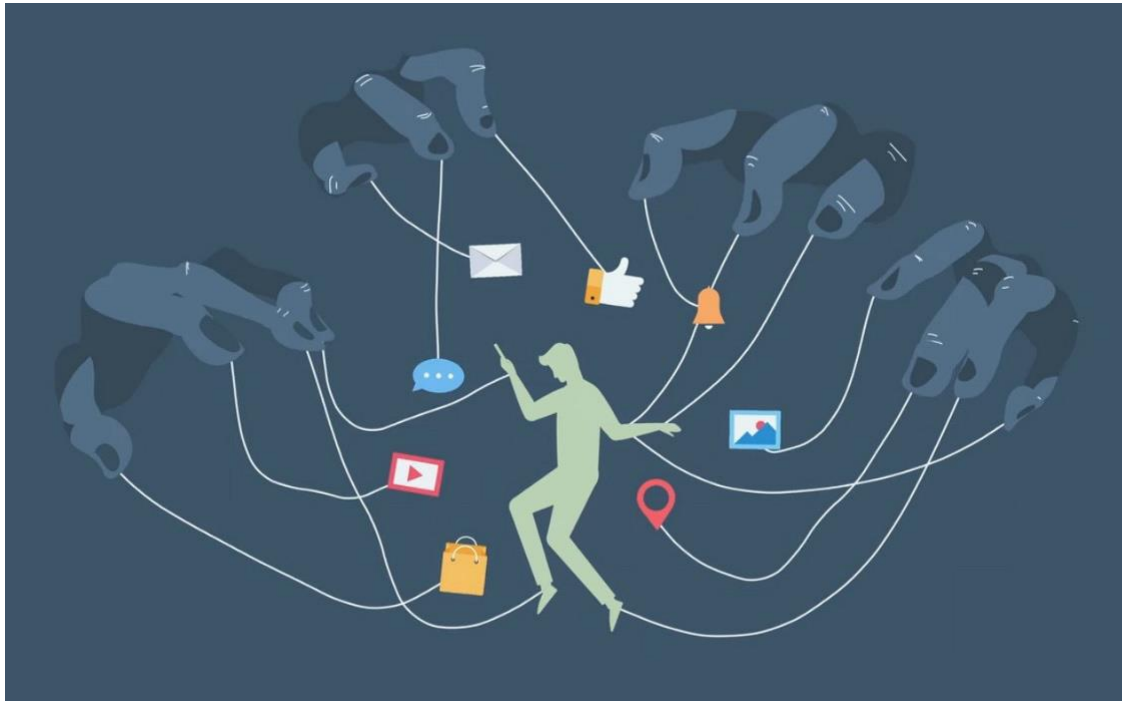
Cybernetics as a Technology of Governmentality

- Origin: Norbert Wiener and mid-20th century systems theory
  - The science of control and communication in the animal and the machine
  - Not just a technical theory; a **political rationality**.
- AI as **applied** cybernetics
  - Traffic optimization systems; smart city infrastructures; platform algorithms

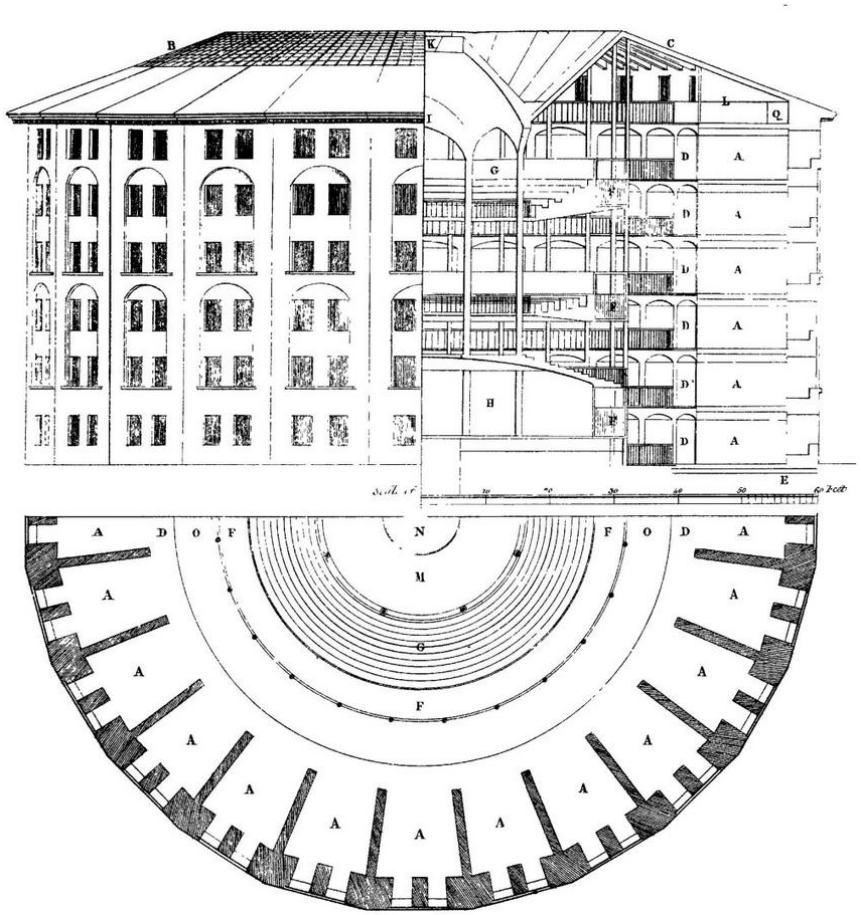


Algorithmic Governmentality

- Governance through metrics, scores, and probabilities.
  - Individuals less as moral or legal subjects than as **data points**
- Automation shaping behavior through **choice** architecture rather than coercion
- reconfigure rather than **eliminate** power struggles

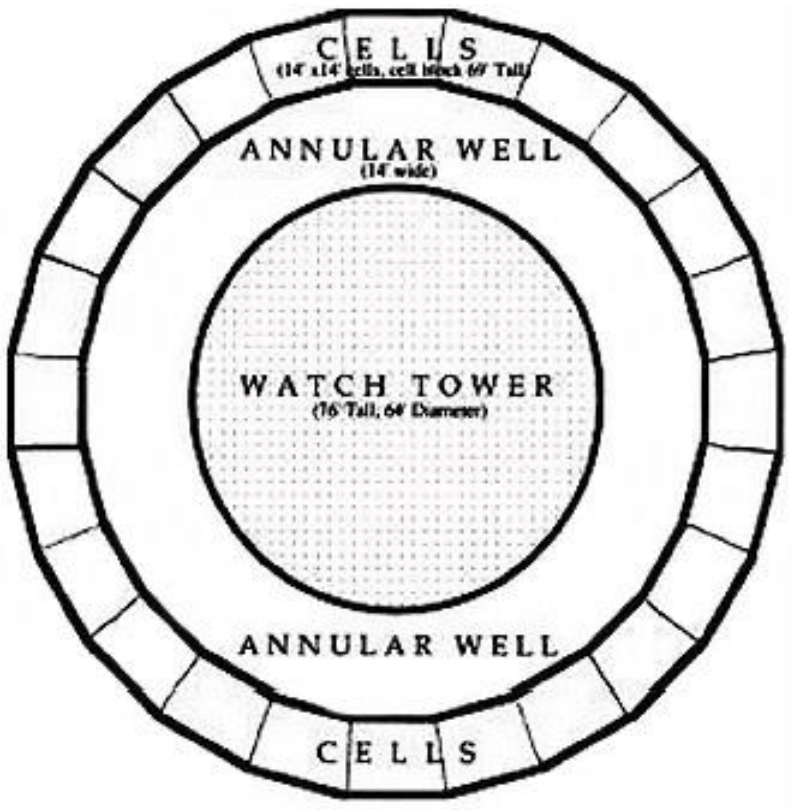


Bentham’s Idea of the Panopticon Prison



The Panopticon

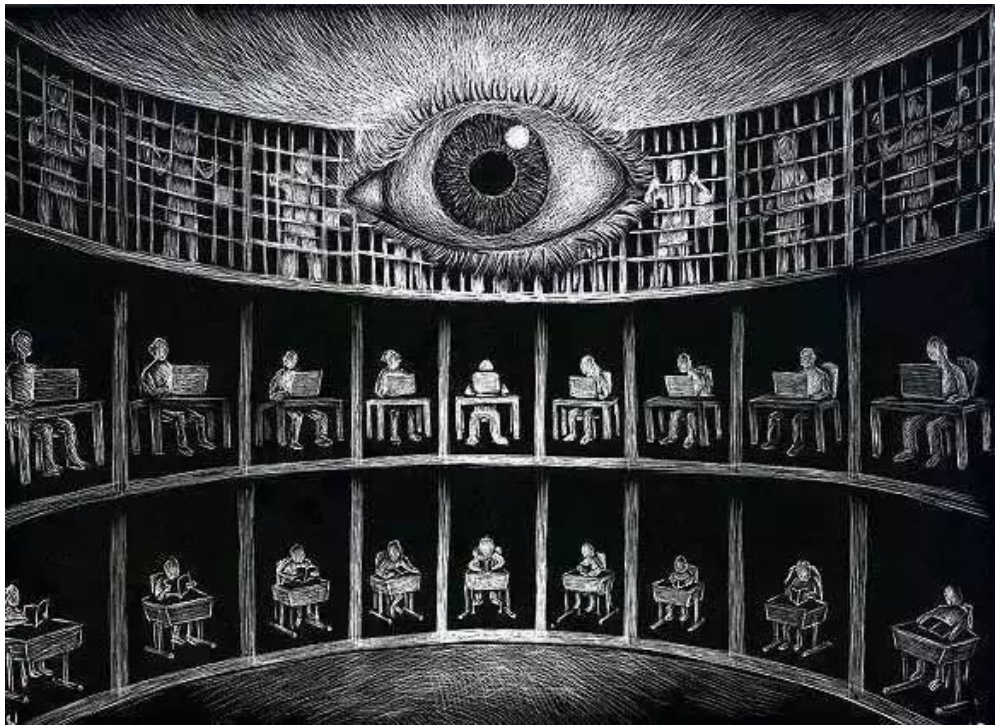
- Etymology: a single watchman to observe (-opticon) all (pan-) prisoners
- Architectural **efficiency**: isolation and **constant visibility** maximize control by producing a sense of **perpetual** surveillance.
- **Internalized** discipline: subjects self-regulate even when not being actively watched



Panopticon schematic, 1791

Mechanism of Control

- The prison as the microcosmos of a society
- Order through **asymmetrical** visibility: vertical visibility + horizontal invisibility
- Punishment shifts from physical torture to **surveillance**
- Automatic functioning of power: mechanism of permanent visibility



Digital Panopticon

- Panopticon in the age of AI
  - CCTV cameras, tracking devices, online platforms, and databases
- The panopticon as no longer **spatial** but **temporal** and digital
- Decentralized surveillance: self-surveillance and **voluntary** participation
- Power **asymmetry** between observers (platforms, states) and the observed

School as A Panopticon

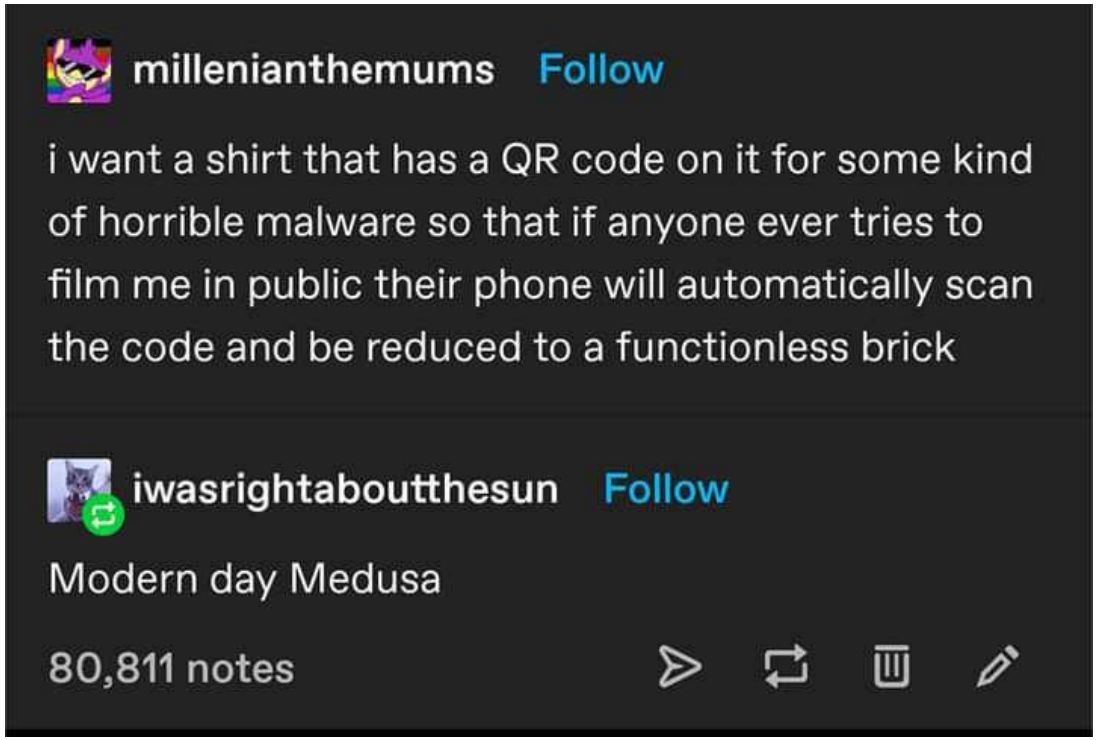
Surveillance Capitalism

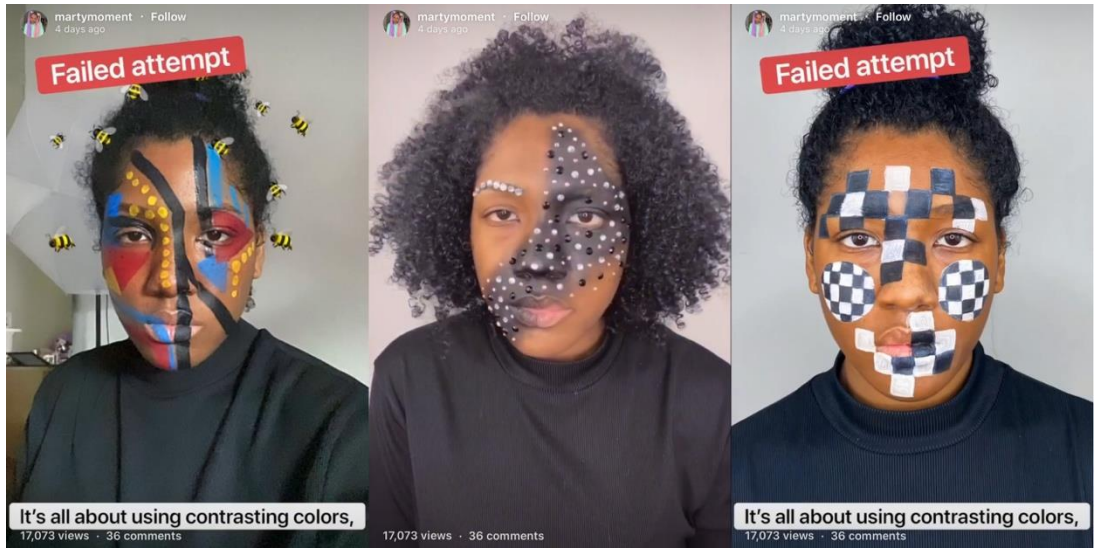
- “Free” digital services in exchange for personal data
- **Commodification** of behavior: everyday actions turned into marketable data
- Business model: sell behavioral insights to advertisers for precision targeting

Workplace Surveillance

- From factory supervision to digital monitoring and algorithmic management
  - Video surveillance; computer monitoring; screen capture; real-time location tracking; phone tapping; key logging; etc.
- Surveillance through **metadata** rather than direct observation
  - Continuous and **scalable** surveillance
  - AI-driven productivity and performance analytics

Surveillance Resistance





Anti-Facial Recognition Makeup